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Saltwater Point University Group 51* case study MGNT110-208 Introduction to Management

Background

Saltwater Point University* is known for its relaxed coastal setting, its proud student culture, its slightly overconfident by-line, and its emphasis on developing practical skills from the first year of study. In the subject Introduction to Organisations, students are required to complete a substantial group task. The assessment takes the form of a written business report worth twenty five percent of the subject grade. The task is designed to help students learn how to collaborate, plan work effectively, share responsibilities, and communicate ideas in a professional written format.

To encourage students to work with a range of peers, the teaching team allocates students to groups rather than allowing them to choose their own. Group 51 consisted of four students who had not previously worked together: Jamal, Lucas, Mia, and Priya. All students are in their first year of study. Mia and Priya are undertaking a Bachelor of Business. Lucas is working towards a Bachelor of Education and Jamal is aiming for a Bachelor of Engineering. Priya and Jamal are international students. Lucas and Mia are domestic students. All four students have part time jobs.

At their first meeting, which took place just before class in the library, Mia opened her laptop, straightened the assessment sheet, and said, “Before class starts, can we please go through the requirements again.” Jamal arrived moments later. She clasped her hands together dramatically and announced, “Ladies and gentlemen, we have been chosen. Group 51. The

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* A fictitious case study

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truth is out there." She paused expectantly. Nothing. She tried again. "You know… Area 51. The Air Force base in Utah. Aliens. Government secrets. Little green men." Still nothing. She nodded slowly and added, "Anyway. I just think it is iconic." Priya offered a sympathetic smile and said, "Whatever works for everyone." Jamal, confused, "huh?" Lucas made a sound that might have been a laugh, then sat down and said, "Hey team, guess who I ran into today…" Mia started reading the assessment requirements and typing.

Like all groups in the subject, Group 51 was required to complete a group expectations document in Week 2, meet regularly throughout the session, and keep clear records of their progress. They were also expected to divide the report into sections, contribute equally to the workload, and upload their drafts to a shared folder well before the final deadline. Mia wrote most of the expectations document herself after the others said "I do not mind either way" and "Happy to do anything." Jamal attempted to add a sketch of how the report could work "as a story", but the group did not fully understand what she meant. Lucas suggested they find a YouTube video he had recently seen which explains business reports, but couldn't located it again. Priya apologised a few times for not knowing how to format the document.

At first, the group appeared to be on track. They created a shared folder, set up a chat group, and successfully held an initial meeting to read the assessment instructions. The following week, Jamal repeatedly asked, "Wait, was I supposed to do the analysis or the recommendation?" Priya responded, "I am not sure… what do you all think?" Lucas enthusiastically volunteered to contact "a mate who did a report last year". Mia reminded everyone twice in the chat to "add three references per section".

The weeks progressed. Their meeting plans repeatedly fell through. Lucas sent cheerful messages such as, "Sorry guys, picked up an extra shift, great opportunity." Jamal took time to respond and sent messages such as, "So I have been thinking…" followed by an idea that needed more explanation. Priya quietly sent private messages to Jamal asking whether her introduction made sense. Mia became increasingly anxious about deadlines and often stayed up late to "just clean up the formatting because it was bothering me." She sent a message at 11.47 pm asking, "Can someone please confirm they have actually read the marking rubric."

Only one member, Mia, consistently produced work, while the others contributed sporadically or not at all. Jamal submitted half formed handwritten notes though the ideas were informed by the textbook and lectures. Lucas uploaded nothing and instead sent links and comments. Priya contributed gentle, tentative drafts but often apologised for not knowing if they were correct.

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Although the group had planned to hold five meetings, they managed only two and documented just one. Their shared folder remained mostly empty. Deadlines were missed, and last minute attempts to coordinate the final report created rising stress among the group. The night before submission, Mia rewrote a full paragraph from Lucas's section and only told him afterwards.

By the time they reached the submission date, the report was complete but lacked detail and cohesion. The Subject Coordinator has requested a meeting with the group to discuss the submission and the variation in contributions. The mark of 62 percent has yet to be applied to each student until the group meets with the Subject Coordinator.

The case materials, available in the Appendices that follow include: a screenshot of their group expectations document (Appendix 1), a selection of their chat messages (Appendix 2), minutes from their only recorded meeting (Appendix 3), informal notes from another meeting from Jamal (Appendix 4), student reflections (Appendix 5), and the tutor's observations after reading the submitted report (Appendix 6).

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Your task

Your team will deliver a presentation during your Week 5 tutorial, using slides that are projected for your audience. In addition, one member of the team must submit the presentation slides to Turnitin (Moodle) by the given deadline.

You are a team of graduates from Saltwater Point University and have been asked to give Group 51 guidance on how to work as a functional group in future. Drawing on the evidence provided in the case study, you are asked to

1. introduce your team and clearly state the purpose of your presentation
2. explain how Group 51 functioned as a team,
3. identify one significant issue for the group related to managing teams or motivation and justify why this issue is significant,
4. analyse this issue using one relevant theory related to managing teams or motivation, and
5. provide recommendations for how the team could resolve or mitigate this issue in the future.
6. include a reference list in your final slide using UOW Harvard referencing style. In-text citations must also be included throughout the presentation slides wherever theory or sources are used.
7. include an acknowledgement of generative AI use (if applicable).

You are required to use the lecture on managing teams and motivation, refer to textbook chapters 3 and 4 (Clegg et al. 2024), and include at least four scholarly references sourced through the UOW Library.

You will present your slides and findings as a team. You will have about 8-12 minutes in total during your tutorial to deliver your presentation, including:

- 8-12mins (2 mins each person) for delivery of your presentation
- 2 minutes to answer audience and tutor questions.

Ask yourself this: Before you present your advice to Group 51, would that advice actually help you if you were in their situation? Effective guidance is practical, realistic, and grounded in the theories you have studied and the evidence you have analysed. Make sure your recommendations are something a real group of first year students could understand and act on.

Review the Subject Outline and marking rubric for further details of the assessment requirements.

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How to reference the case study

Schulz, R 2026, *Saltwater Point University Group 51 case study*, MGNT110-208 Introduction to Management, University of Wollongong, viewed < insert date >, <insert link to case study document>.

How to reference the textbook

Clegg, S, Pitsis, T & Mount, M 2024, *Managing & Organizations: An Introduction to Theory and Practice*, 7th edn, Sage, Los Angeles.

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APPENDICES

Appendix 1: Group expectation document for Group 51

Saltwater Point University
Introduction to Organisations
Group 51
Group Expectations Document
Week 2

As a group, we are committed to producing a High Distinction standard business report for Assessment One. We agree that aiming for the highest possible mark will motivate us to do our best work and support each other throughout the task.

We agree to the following expectations:

1. We will all aim for a High Distinction.
2. We will try to meet regularly when possible.
3. We will each contribute to the report in our own way.
4. We will communicate in the group chat and reply when we can.
5. We will upload our drafts to the shared folder once they are ready.
6. We will encourage each other to stay on track.
7. We will avoid conflict and keep things positive.
8. We will respect each other’s ideas and effort.
9. We will do our best to finish the report before the due date.
10. We will make the report look professional.

Signatures (typed, not signed):

Mia
Priya
Lucas
Jamal

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Appendix 2: Messages from Mia's phone

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Appendix 3: Minutes of meeting

Saltwater Point University
Introduction to Organisations
Group 51
Meeting One Minutes
Week 2
Library, Ground Floor

Present: Mia (taking notes), Priya, Jamal, [Lucas (arrived at 4.00pm)]
Absent: None
Start time: 3.12 pm
Finish time: 4.34 pm

1. Purpose of meeting
To read through the assessment instructions and decide how to start the group report.

2. Assessment instructions
The group opened the task sheet on Mia's laptop.
General agreement that the task looks "long".
Priya asked what a business report is supposed to look like.
Jamal said she had written one in high school "but it might be different here".

3. Allocation of sections
Mia suggested dividing the report into four sections.
Jamal asked if the introduction could be shorter because "it is just a summary".
Priya asked if the conclusion had a word limit.
No final agreement was reached.
Group decided to "each write something" before the next meeting.

4. Roles
Mia asked if someone wanted to coordinate the group.
Lucas just turned up and said he is happy to help but is busy with work.
Jamal said she is "more of an ideas person".
Priya said she does not mind what role she has.
No roles assigned.

5. Communication
Group agreed to use WhatsApp.
Mia created the group chat called "Group 51".
Jamal immediately commented on the number 51.
Mia asked everyone to stay focused.

6. Meetings
Mia suggested five meetings before submission.
Lucas said he is rostered on a lot of shifts but will try.
Priya said evenings work for her.

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Jamal said mornings are “dangerous” because she never wakes up on time.
No dates were set.

7. Shared folder
Mia created a shared folder and posted the link in the chat.
Priya said she will check it tonight.
Lucas said he will check when he gets time.
Jamal said she accidentally opened her photos instead of the folder.

8. Closing
Mia asked everyone to please read the task sheet before the next meeting.
General nodding.

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Appendix 4: Jamal's informal notes

Trying to figure out which OB theories we could use for the assignment.
We need at least two strong ones.
Mia wants us to choose tonight... ok then.

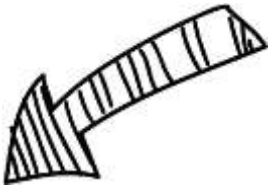
1. Social identity theory
- People define themselves by group memberships
- In workplace settings, identity shapes behaviour, loyalty, communication
- In groups, members categorise themselves as "us" and "them"
- Can influence confidence, participation, motivation
- Theory originally from psychology but used in OB for teamwork and leadership
- Could apply this to the case study we are analysing
(check lecture slides... if Lucas ever uploads them... joking. mostly.)

Key point for report:
Explain how identity influences how staff behave in organisations.
Maybe link to belonging, morale, collaboration.
Need example from textbook or article.

2. Equity theory
- People compare their effort and rewards with others
- If they feel it is unfair, motivation drops
- OB uses it to explain job satisfaction, turnover, engagement
- Useful for analysing any case involving workload, reward systems, fairness
(should make sure I understand input versus output properly before writing.)

Key point for report:
Explain how perceptions of fairness affect behaviour at work.
Show how imbalance leads to withdrawal or frustration.
Find a good scholarly reference for this.

Possible structure for our report
Intro
Theory one explanation
Apply to scenario in task sheet
Theory two explanation
Apply to scenario
Short conclusion
(edit this later once everyone has done their sections... assuming they do... deep breath.)



To do
Find two articles
Write my section in proper academic tone
Try not to sound confused
Ask Mia if this approach works (when she is in a calm mood)
Also remind Priya gently that she needs to upload something
(should I text her or is that too much... hmm)

Side note:
Why did I pick a business subject in first year??? Urghhh....
Actually interesting though....but won't tell the tutor hee hee

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Appendix 5:

During Week 4, each member of Group 51 was asked to write a short in class reflection about what drives them when working on university tasks. These are the unedited statements they submitted.

Priya's reflection

What matters to me is feeling comfortable in group and know we are working good together. I try to support everyone and make sure no one feels left out. I like contributing in ways that help the whole group stay together, even if my part is small. When people are calm and working well together, I feel confident to do my best. I prefer when we are all on the same page and no one is stressed or upset.

Mia's reflection

I like knowing that I have done something well and that it is the best version I could produce. When I work on assignments, I always read through the instructions carefully and check that every detail is right. I feel most satisfied when the work is clear, polished, and finished properly. Even if the task is frustrating, I prefer to stay with it until it feels complete. It matters to me that my work meets my own standards, not just the expectations on the task sheet.

Lucas's reflection

For me, I put in effort when I know it is going to be worth something in the end. If a task leads to a good mark or helps me pass the subject, then I am into it. If it feels like a lot of work for not much gain, I honestly struggle to stay focused. I usually try to ask people who have done the subject before, because they normally know shortcuts or better ways of doing things. If someone already has a good approach, I would rather use that than start from scratch. I work best when I can see a clear pay off.

Jamal's reflection

I get most interested in a task when something in it opens up a way of thinking I had not considered before. Sometimes it is a small detail, but it shifts how I see the whole problem, almost like changing the angle of a lens. When that happens, I like to explore the pattern behind it and see how the different pieces fit together. I enjoy following ideas that do not look connected at first, because they often turn out to explain something bigger once you trace them back. I sometimes sketch shapes or write fragments before I draft properly because it helps me work out the structure of an argument. I like when a task gives me space to interpret what is going on, not just repeat what was given. Once the meaning becomes clear, the writing flows much more easily.

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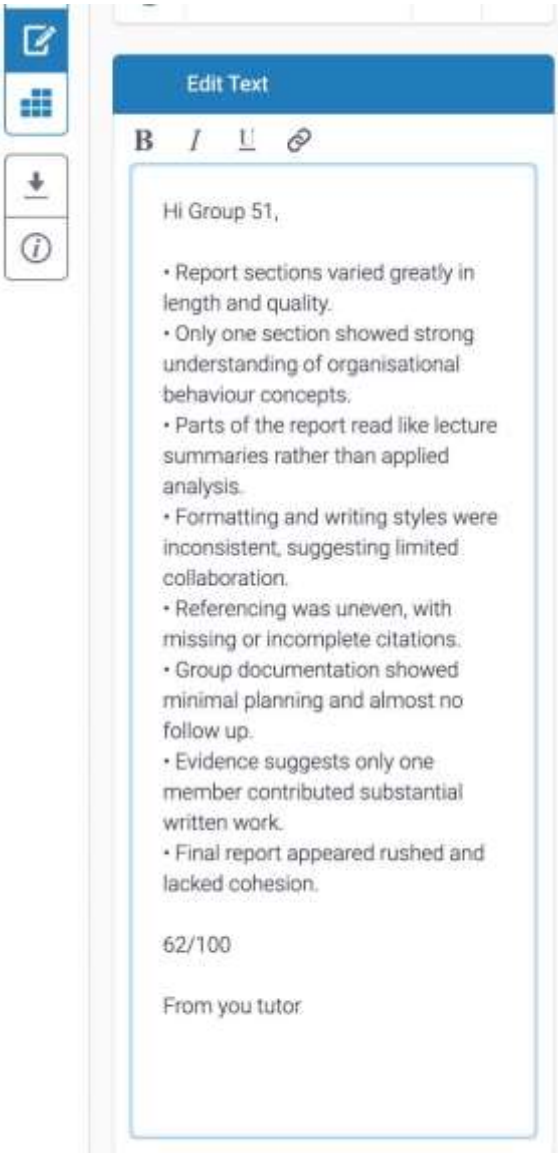
Appendix 6: Tutor's observations



Edit Text

Hi Group 51,

• Report sections varied greatly in length and quality.
• Only one section showed strong understanding of organisational behaviour concepts.
• Parts of the report read like lecture summaries rather than applied analysis.
• Formatting and writing styles were inconsistent, suggesting limited collaboration.
• Referencing was uneven, with missing or incomplete citations.
• Group documentation showed minimal planning and almost no follow up.
• Evidence suggests only one member contributed substantial written work.
• Final report appeared rushed and lacked cohesion.

62/100

From you tutor

END OF DOCUMENT